Music 103 Midterm Study Guide

Oct 5, 2026 · @Michael J

Midterm on Oct 16, 2026, covering Weeks 1–6. Built from the official review sheet and checked against the weekly notes.

Exam at a Glance

50 minutes, 50 marks, all multiple choice on Scantron. Ends at 2:50 p.m.

Section	Marks	Format
1. Listening	20	4 excerpts × 5 questions each. Each excerpt played **twice**, audio only, no visuals, only part of the song
2. Regular multiple choice	30	Artists, definitions, songs, genres, issues, context — from **required readings and all lecture materials**

The listening section comes first. After the last excerpt you can move on to Section 2 whenever you like.

What the sample questions tell you. For one excerpt ("Maple Leaf Rag") the five questions cover **who performed it**, **what year**, and **why it is significant**. So for every song on the list you need artist, year, label and significance. The significance answers are framed as the course frames them ("it exemplifies the ragtime sound"), and the distractors are sometimes jokes ("David Brackett says it's important").

Section 2 samples: **"Subjectivity can be defined as…"** → *the condition of being a subject* (Brabazon, Week 1). **"'Golden' can be best described as…"** → almost certainly *all of the above*: a summer song, a major hit, and an example of **changing metrics around measuring listenership** (Week 1.2's Billboard and Luminate charts).

Bring: HB No. 2 pencil and your **ONEcard**. Nothing else on the desk; bags and phones under the seat. Fill in your name, student ID and the **3-digit Special Code** (your exam version) on the Scantron — getting this right is your responsibility. If you usually finish early, sit near the aisle.

The 20 Songs

The review sheet says to study **record label, recording year, recording artist and the larger significance** of each. Four excerpts in the listening section will come from this list.

Label sources: labels with no mark appear on the course slides. Labels marked † come from standard discographies, not the slides — check them against the Brackett reader if you can. Week 6 rows now follow the 6.1–6.3 slides.

#	Song	Artist	Year	Label	Significance	Notes
1	"You'd Be Surprised"	Billy Murray (written by Irving Berlin)	c. 1919–20	OKeh	The Berlin song form: piano intro, vamp, verses, chorus. Tin Pan Alley's standardised song reaching record	Week 2
2	"One O'Clock Jump"	Count Basie	1937	Decca †	Jazz standard, 12-bar blues instrumental, the orchestra's theme song, Basie's "riff style." Swing era	Week 2
3	"The Prisoner's Song"	Vernon Dalhart	1924	Victor †	Cost 7 cents to make and sold millions. Marketed as "hillbilly," one of the best-selling songs of the 1920s	Week 2
4	"No Depression in Heaven"	The Carter Family	1936	Decca †	Rural Appalachian experience of the Depression. Maybelle's "Carter style" thumb picking. Influence on bluegrass, country, rock, pop	Week 2
5	"Sweet Home Chicago"	Robert Johnson	1936/37	Vocalion (ARC) †	Delta blues; the textbook AAB 12-bar example; crossroads myth	Week 3
6	"Hoochie Coochie Man"	Muddy Waters (written by Willie Dixon)	1954	Chess †	Chicago blues standard: electrified, full band, stop time, call and response	Week 3

#	Song	Artist	Year	Label	Significance	Notes
7	"Your Cheatin' Heart"	Hank Williams	1952/53	MGM †	Honky-tonk: steel guitar, fiddle, nasal vocal, small band; Williams as the lonely figure	Week 3
8	"I Fall to Pieces"	Patsy Cline	1961	Decca †	The Nashville Sound: Jordanaires backing vocals, yodel removed, studio musicians. Crossover country/pop	Week 3
9	"Strange Things Happening Every Day"	Sister Rosetta Tharpe	1944/45	Decca †	First big gospel/race-records crossover. Electric guitar as lead instrument before rock 'n' roll	Week 3
10	"What'd I Say" ("What I'd Say")	Ray Charles	1959	Atlantic	Crystallised soul. Melisma, call and response with the Raelettes, live improvisation. Split into Parts 1 and 2; banned by some stations	Week 3 / Week 4
11	"Maybellene"	Chuck Berry	1955	Chess †	From Bob Wills's "Ida Red" (country). Car-culture teen narrative; 12-bar; guitar solo	Week 4
12	"That's All Right"	Elvis Presley	1954	Sun	First major record; Sam Phillips. Arthur Crudup original (1946). Trio; rockabilly; voice "juxtaposing" styles	Week 4
13	"Hound Dog"	Elvis Presley	1956	RCA Victor	"Radically transformed" Big Mama Thornton's 1952 R&B hit. Milton Berle TV controversy, "Elvis the Pelvis"	Week 4

#	Song	Artist	Year	Label	Significance	Notes
14	"The Twist"	Chubby Checker	1960	Parkway †	Written by Hank Ballard (1959). No. 1 in 1960 and 1962. Dance craze; *Dick Clark Saturday Night Show*	Week 5
15	"Be My Baby"	The Ronettes	1963	Philles	Greenwich, Barry, Spector. Wall of Sound, Gold Star Studios, Hal Blaine's drum intro	Week 5
16	"Surfin' U.S.A."	The Beach Boys	1963	Capitol †	Surf music. Melody taken from Chuck Berry's "Sweet Little Sixteen"; Berry later received credit	*Week 6 (slides)*
17	"Wouldn't It Be Nice"	The Beach Boys	1966	Capitol	Opens *Pet Sounds*; Brian Wilson's studio-as-instrument production with Wrecking Crew session players	*Week 6 (slides)*
18	"Subterranean Homesick Blues"	Bob Dylan	1965	Columbia †	Dylan's move to electric folk rock, the year he went electric at the Newport Folk Festival	Week 6.2
19	"You Keep Me Hangin' On"	The Supremes	1966	Motown †	Motown girl group; Holland–Dozier–Holland songwriting	Week 6.3
20	"Respect"	Aretha Franklin	1967	Atlantic †	Otis Redding's song reworked into a soul, civil-rights and feminist anthem	Week 6.3

One correction this exposes in the notes. Your Week 2 notes list "You'd Be Surprised" under Irving Berlin. The review sheet credits the **performer, Billy Murray** — Berlin wrote it. If the exam asks "the artist who performed this recording," the answer is Murray.

Listening Section: Recognising Each Excerpt

You'll hear only part of each song, with no title. First work out the era from the recording quality, then use one or two cues you can actually hear. Practise by playing a random 30 seconds of each song and naming it.

Step 1 — era by sound

What you hear	Probably
Thin, tinny, acoustic-era recording; formal vocal	1910s–20s: Murray, Dalhart
Big band with horns, no vocal	Basie
One voice + one acoustic guitar	Robert Johnson
Harmony singing over picked acoustic guitar, old-time feel	Carter Family
Steel guitar and fiddle	Hank Williams (rawer) or Patsy Cline (smoother, backing choir)
Electric guitar under a sacred lyric	Sister Rosetta Tharpe
Clear electric band, 1950s backbeat	Waters, Berry, Presley, Charles
Huge, echoing orchestral pop	The Ronettes (Spector)

Step 2 — the giveaway cue for each song

Song	Listen for
"You'd Be Surprised"	Old acoustic recording, comic Tin Pan Alley vocal, orchestra; verse-chorus song form
"One O'Clock Jump"	Instrumental; boogie-ish piano, then horn sections trading short **riffs**; 12-bar
"The Prisoner's Song"	Plaintive, sentimental solo vocal; sparse accompaniment; mournful lyric
"No Depression in Heaven"	Group harmony; Maybelle's thumb-picked melody on the low strings; lyrics about the Depression and heaven

Song	Listen for
"Sweet Home Chicago"	Solo acoustic guitar with a walking boogie bass line; "Oh baby don't you want to go" repeated twice, then the answering line
"Hoochie Coochie Man"	The **stop-time riff**: band hits, silence, voice; harmonica; amplified band
"Your Cheatin' Heart"	Steel guitar, fiddle, small band, sad slow ballad; nasal, aching vocal
"I Fall to Pieces"	Polished, slow; female lead; **Jordanaires** background vocals (faint); no yodel
"Strange Things Happening Every Day"	Gospel lyric ("judgment"), piano and **electric guitar solo**
"What'd I Say"	**Electric piano** riff; call and response, "hey / ho" exchanges with the Raelettes
"Maybellene"	Fast; car chase lyrics (Cadillac, Ford); twangy guitar solo
"That's All Right"	Just three players — guitar, bass, rhythm guitar — and Elvis's light, jumpy voice; no drums
"Hound Dog"	Loud drums, backing vocals, "You ain't nothin' but a hound dog" shouted
"The Twist"	Dance instructions in the lyric ("Come on baby, let's do the twist")
"Be My Baby"	**Drum intro: boom, boom-boom, CRACK**; dense echo; strings and castanets

Easy confusions to drill

- "That's All Right" vs "Hound Dog": both Elvis — *no drums and three players* = 1954 Sun; *drums and backing singers* = 1956 RCA
- "Your Cheatin' Heart" vs "I Fall to Pieces": both steel-guitar ballads — male and rawer = Williams; female with a backing choir = Cline
- "Hoochie Coochie Man" vs "Sweet Home Chicago": both blues — *electric band* = Waters, Chicago; *solo acoustic* = Johnson, Delta

The five Week 6 songs aren't in the table yet; see the next sections.

Review-Sheet Topics, Checked Against the Notes

Every topic the review sheet lists, with where it lives in your notes. **Thin** = present but short; **Missing** = not in the notes.

Week 1 — notes

Topic	Status
Subjectivity	Covered
Defining Popular Music	Covered
Writing about Music	Covered — but it sits in the **Week 2** notes (Brabazon 36, 40)
Listening to Music	Covered
The Industrialization of Music (Frith)	Covered
Elements of Music	Covered
"Golden" and listenership metrics	**Thin** — a sample question, but the notes mention it only in passing

Week 2 — notes

Topic	Status
Tin Pan Alley; Irving Berlin	Covered
Music and Technology (sheet music, records, radio)	Covered
The Jazz Age; Jazz in the 1920s; Paul Whiteman; Louis Armstrong	Covered
Cultural Appropriation	Covered
Commodification	Covered via Frith ("music-as-commodity") — learn the word itself
The Swing Era; Count Basie	Covered

Topic	Status
Racial Politics and Stereotypes	Covered via minstrelsy, race records, Whiteman
Hillbilly Music; Vernon Dalhart; Carter Family	Covered
Race Records; Classic Blues; Bessie Smith	Covered

Week 3 — notes

Topic	Status
Context behind R&B and Country; Radio DJs	Covered
Blues and its Structure; Three Periods of Blues	Covered
Instrumentation — Country and Blues; Country and Lyrics	Covered
Western Swing and Honky-Tonk; Popularity of Country	Covered
Nashville and Nashville Sound; Grand Ole Opry and WSM	Covered
Gospel and Soul	Covered
Robert Johnson, Muddy Waters, T-Bone Walker, Hank Williams, Bob Wills, Patsy Cline, Sister Rosetta Tharpe, Ray Charles	Covered

Week 4 — notes

Topic	Status
Guitar; Rock and Roll as a Genre	Covered
Rock and Racial Boundaries; Youth Culture	Covered
Rock and Roll and the Popular Press; Rock and Moral Panics	Covered
Bill Haley; Chuck Berry; Little Richard; Willie Mae Thornton; Elvis Presley	Covered

Week 5 — notes

Topic	Status
Music and visuality; Music videos	Covered (slides only)
David Bowie and "Ashes to Ashes"	**Thin** — the slides show only the cover; it's named on the review sheet, so the lecture said more
Payola; Teen Pop and *American Bandstand*	Covered (slides only)
Brill Building and songwriting; Girl Groups	Covered (slides only)
The studio and production; Session musicians; Phil Spector	Covered (slides only)

Week 6 — Covered from the 6.1, 6.2 and 6.3 slides: surf and the Beach Boys, folk rock, urban folk and Dylan/Newport, soul, Motown, the Supremes and Aretha. Notes: https://claude.ai/code/artifact/5b1798dd-6f8c-45c1-ac6f-4548cc59b175

Surf; The Beach Boys; Urban Folk and Folk Rock; Bob Dylan; Electric guitar and Newport Folk Festival; Soul Music and Civil Rights; Motown; The Supremes; Aretha Franklin.

Gaps to Close Before the Exam

In order of how many marks they could cost:

- [x] ~~**Week 6 slides.** Done: the 6.2 and 6.3 slides are now in the Week 6 notes. Still no Week 6 lecture recording, so anything said only out loud in class is missing.~~

- [ ] **Labels marked † in the song table.** The review sheet asks for labels specifically, and most labels never appeared on the slides. Check them against the Brackett reader's headnotes, which usually give label and year.
- [ ] **Week 5 lecture recording.** The notes are slides-only. The review sheet names "David Bowie and 'Ashes to Ashes'" and "The studio and production" as topics, so the lecture said more than the slides show.
- [ ] **"Golden" and listenership metrics.** It's a sample question, so assume the real exam has one like it. Know: HUNTR/X, *KPop Demon Hunters* soundtrack, No. 1 on the Hot 100 (10 weeks on the chart by September 6, 2025); the soundtrack's share of all K-pop streaming rose to around 40%. The point is that streaming has changed *how a hit is counted*.
- [ ] **Billy Murray.** Fix the Week 2 notes: he is the performer of "You'd Be Surprised."
- [ ] **"Commodification" as a term.** It's listed for Week 2. One-line answer: turning music into a product made and sold for profit — Frith's "music-as-commodity."

If Week 6 slides don't arrive in time, these are the general-history basics behind the review-sheet topics:

- **Surf / the Beach Boys** — early-60s California youth music; close harmony over Chuck Berry–style guitar ("Surfin' U.S.A." uses Berry's "Sweet Little Sixteen"). By 1966 Brian Wilson uses the studio as an instrument (*Pet Sounds*)
- **Urban folk and folk rock; Bob Dylan; Newport** — the early-60s folk revival prized acoustic "authenticity." Dylan played an electric set at the Newport Folk Festival in 1965 and was booed by part of the audience. It's the rock/pop authenticity argument from Week 1, inside folk
- **Soul music and civil rights; Motown; the Supremes; Aretha Franklin** — Berry Gordy's Detroit label ran a production-line model like the Brill Building and aimed for crossover to white audiences. Aretha's "Respect" (Atlantic, 1967) became a civil-rights and feminist anthem — soul's political orientation, as Week 3 flagged

Practice Questions

Written in the style of the review sheet's samples. Answers are at the end of the section — cover them first.

Listening-style (imagine you've just heard the excerpt)

1. *(Excerpt: "That's All Right")* The label that released this recording was: A) RCA Victor B) Chess C) Sun D) Atlantic

2. *(Same excerpt)* The song was originally recorded by: A) Big Mama Thornton B) Arthur Crudup C) Hank Ballard D) Bob Wills

3. *(Excerpt: "I Fall to Pieces")* This recording is significant because: A) It was the first No. 1 by an all-girl group B) It exemplifies the Nashville Sound C) It was banned by radio stations D) It introduced the electric steel guitar

4. *(Excerpt: "Hoochie Coochie Man")* The song was written by: A) Muddy Waters B) Robert Johnson C) Willie Dixon D) T-Bone Walker

5. *(Excerpt: "Be My Baby")* The production technique heard here is known as: A) The Nashville Sound B) The Wall of Sound C) Rockabilly D) Stop time

Regular multiple choice

6. At OKeh Records, Black artists were assigned to the 14000 series and white artists to the: A) 13000 Race Series B) 15000 Hillbilly Series C) 16000 Folk Series D) 15000 Country and Western Series

7. Paul Whiteman was called "the King of Jazz" because of: A) His improvised trumpet solos B) The association between "jazz" and "sweet dance music" C) His work with Louis Armstrong D) Leading the first integrated orchestra

8. "Mechanicals" are: A) Royalties from recorded music B) Studio session musicians C) Player pianos D) Jukebox operators

9. In 1949, *Billboard* renamed its "race" chart: A) Soul B) Rhythm and Blues C) Urban D) Rock and Roll

10. Which DJ was indicted in 1960 for accepting $2,500 in payola? A) Dick Clark B) Jack L. Cooper C) Alan Freed D) Sam Phillips

11. "Hound Dog" was a 1952 R&B hit for: A) Bessie Smith B) Sister Rosetta Tharpe C) Willie Mae "Big Mama" Thornton D) Darlene Love

12. "He's a Rebel" (1962) was credited to the Crystals but actually sung by: A) Ronnie Spector B) Darlene Love C) Little Eva D) The Shirelles

13. According to Brabazon, girl groups were significant because: A) They played their own instruments B) They wrote their own songs C) Female subjectivity was widely represented for the first time D) They ended the payola scandal

14. "Maybellene" was adapted from: A) "Ida Red" by Bob Wills B) "Rock the Joint" by Jimmy Preston C) "It Must Be Jesus" by the Southern Tones D) "Sweet Home Chicago" by Robert Johnson

15. The 12-bar blues is structured as: A) ABA B) AABA C) AAB D) ABAB

Answers: 1 C · 2 B · 3 B · 4 C · 5 B · 6 B · 7 B · 8 A · 9 B · 10 C · 11 C · 12 B · 13 C · 14 A · 15 C

How the Instructor Says to Study

From the review sheet, condensed:

1. **Lectures first.** Use them to find the key areas, then expand through readings and lecture examples.
2. **Read for the big picture.** Definitions, terms and concepts from lecture matter; very small or abstract details don't.
3. **Use the Brackett headnotes.** The short bold sections before each excerpt in the Brackett reader set up the big-picture ideas. This is also the fastest place to confirm the † labels and years.
4. **Skip what doesn't match lecture.** Pay attention to the parts of the readings that line up with lecture topics, examples and issues; spend less time on the rest.

A plan for the next 11 days, given that tip 1 assumes lecture notes you mostly have:

When	Do
This week	Get the Week 6 slides as they're posted; drill the listening cues for songs 1–15
Weekend	Brackett headnotes for every song on the list — confirm labels and years
Next week, early	Week 6 notes; add songs 16–20 to your listening drill
Two days before	Practice questions; the "easy confusions" pairs; random 30-second excerpts of all 20
Night before	Self-check lists at the end of each week's notes